breakdown in authority occurred, either the Pakistani security services were unable to control HuA or HuA's leaders were unable to control some of its commanders in Indian-administered Kashmir. The entire episode was a source of embarrassment for Pakistan internationally. A number of Western governments understandably got involved when their citizens went missing. In 1997 the US banned HuA, forcing the group to change its name back to Harkat-ul-Mujahideen [HuM] in an attempt to escape legal sanction.[39] It continued to play a role in the Kashmir jihad, but by this time was becoming increasingly Afghan focused as the Taliban rose to power. The HuJI faction, which had reunited with the group in 1993 to form HuA, split and re-established its independence. Its preoccupation with Afghanistan also deepened.

Beyond the possible risks associated with relying too heavily on HuA, the group was not operationally well-suited to the army's strategy in the mid-1990s either. The conflict was initially confined primarily to the Valley, but by 1995 militants there were meeting heavy resistance and the insurgency was stagnating. This contributed to the Pakistan army's desire to expand the fighting to Jammu in an effort to revive the conflict. The Valley remained the center of the conflict, but in 1996–1997 the Jammu districts of Rajouri and Poonch witnessed increased activity.[40] Although both are Muslim-majority districts, the town center for administration, commerce and education in each is predominately Hindu and Sikh. In addition to the fact the Indian counter-insurgency had made operations in the Kashmir Valley more difficult, the Pakistan army wanted to expand into Rajouri and Poonch in order to drive out the non-Muslim population. The aim was to increase the Muslim majority in the region for political purposes, and to make it easier for the insurgents to operate.[41]

Militants had made initial inroads into the Jammu district of Doda, but Rajouri and Poonch were relatively quiet during the early years of the insurgency despite being Muslim-dominated and lying alongside 250 kilometers of hilly border on the LoC. Sumantra Bose suggests three reasons why. First, unlike Doda, the Muslims in Rajouri and Poonch are ethno-linguistically different from the Valley's population. Instead, the population in both these districts shares ethnolinguistic ties with those living in Pakistan-administered Kashmir and Punjab province. This made operating there more difficult for the Valley Kashmiris who provided much